

Opening VS Code From The Terminal Via Code

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Today I Learned added on 2025-11-30, learned on 2025-11-30; edited on 2026-06-14.

For my paid and unpaid programming work I've used [VS Code](#). The following has been routine for me for roughly 4 years: I open the target folder by pressing the **Open** button on VS Code's platform or, if I remember to, to **Cmd+O** on my MacOS to open a folder.

Today, I remarked internally to myself that VS Code probably has a method to open a new window from within the Terminal. Lo and behold, it does: `code .` to open the current directory in VS Code.

Of note, to get the `code` command working, I performed the following actions:

1. Open VS Code.
2. Open Command Palette via **Cmd+Shift+P**.
3. Type: "shell command"
4. Select: "Shell Command: Install 'code' command in PATH"
5. Gave permissions to VS Code.

Running `code --help` shows some other interesting options:

```
code --help
Visual Studio Code 1.105.1
```

```
Usage: code [options] [paths...]
```

To read from stdin, append '-' (e.g. `'ps aux | grep code | code -'`)

Options

<code>-d --diff <file> <file></code>	Compare two files with each other.
<code>-m --merge <path1> <path2> <base> <result></code>	Perform a three-way merge by providing paths for each file, the common origin of both modified versions, and the merge results.
<code>-a --add <folder></code>	Add folder(s) to the last active window.
<code>--remove <folder></code>	Remove folder(s) from the last active window.
<code>-g --goto <file:line[:character]></code>	Open a file at the path on the specified line and character.
<code>-n --new-window</code>	Force to open a new window.
<code>-r --reuse-window</code>	Force to open a file or folder in an already open window.
<code>-w --wait</code>	Wait for the files to be closed before returning.
<code>--locale <locale></code>	The locale to use (e.g. en-US or zh-TW).
<code>--user-data-dir <dir></code>	Specifies the directory that user data is kept for multiple distinct instances of Code.
<code>--profile <profileName></code>	Opens the provided folder or workspace with the specified profile. If the profile does not exist, a new one is created.

<code>-h --help</code>	Print usage.
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Extensions Management

<code>--extensions-dir <dir></code>	Set the root path for extensions.
<code>--list-extensions</code>	List the installed extensions.
<code>--show-versions</code>	Show versions of installed extensions, when using <code>--list-extensions</code> .
<code>--category <category></code>	Filters installed extensions by provided category, when using <code>--list-extensions</code> .
<code>--install-extension <ext-id path></code>	Installs or updates an extension. The argument is either a path to a VSIX or an extension identifier. The identifier of an extension is ' <code>{publisher}.{name}@{version}</code> '. For example: <code>'vscode.csharp@1.2.3'</code> .
<code>--force</code>	Force install the extension, even if it is already installed.
<code>--pre-release</code>	Installs the pre-release version of the extension, when using <code>--install-extension</code> .
<code>--uninstall-extension <ext-id></code>	Uninstalls an extension.
<code>--update-extensions</code>	Update the installed extensions.
<code>--enable-proposed-api <ext-id></code>	Enables proposed API features for extensions. Can receive multiple arguments to enable individually.

Model Context Protocol

<code>--add-mcp <json></code>	Adds a Model Context Protocol server definition to the user profile. Accepts a JSON string like <code>'{"name":"server-name","command":...}'</code> .
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Troubleshooting

<code>-v --version</code>	Print version.
<code>--verbose</code>	Print verbose output (implies <code>--log <level></code>).
<code>--log <level></code>	Log level to use. Default is 'info'. Allowed values are 'warn', 'info', 'debug', 'trace', 'off'. You can also filter logs by extension by passing extension id and log level: <code>'{publisher}.{name}:{logLevel}'</code> . For example: <code>'ms-vscode.csharp:debug'</code> . You can receive one or more such entries.
<code>-s --status</code>	Print process usage and diagnostics information.
<code>--prof-startup</code>	Run CPU profiler during startup.
<code>--disable-extensions</code>	Disable all installed extensions. This option is only when the command opens a new window.
<code>--disable-extension <ext-id></code>	Disable the provided extension. This option is only when the command opens a new window.
<code>--sync <on off></code>	Turn sync on or off.
<code>--inspect-extensions <port></code>	Allow debugging and profiling of extensions. Check the developer tools for the connection URI.
<code>--inspect-brk-extensions <port></code>	Allow debugging and profiling of extensions with breakpoints. Check the developer tools for the connection URI after start. Check the developer tools for the connection URI.
<code>--disable-lcd-text</code>	Disable LCD font rendering.
<code>--disable-gpu</code>	Disable GPU hardware acceleration.
<code>--disable-chromium-sandbox</code>	Use this option only when there is requirement to run as root user on Linux or when running as an elevated user on Windows.
<code>--locate-shell-integration-path <shell></code>	Print the path to a terminal shell integration script.

	'bash', 'pwsh', 'zsh' or 'fish'.
--telemetry	Shows all telemetry events which VS code collects
--transient	Run with temporary data and extension directories time.

Subcommands

chat	Pass in a prompt to run in a chat session in the current working directory.
serve-web	Run a server that displays the editor UI in browsers.
tunnel	Make the current machine accessible from vscode.dev or other machines through